

Friday, 09 January 2026

## Every Child Guaranteed a School Placement



Back to School Campaign at Mathupa Primary School in Marite.

Mpumalanga MEC for Education, Ms Linda Masina, on Tuesday 6 January 2026 launched the 2026 Back to School Campaign at Mathupa Primary School in Marite, reaffirming the department's commitment to ensuring that every learner is placed in a school by the end of January.

Addressing parents, guardians and community members, MEC Masina acknowledged that while not all learners may be placed by the official

reopening date of 14 January, the department is working to ensure that no child is left behind. To date, more than 1.3 million learners have been successfully placed across the province, with approximately 9 826 learners still awaiting placement.

The department has established a dedicated help desk to assist parents with placement queries and appeals, as part of efforts to streamline the process and reduce anxiety ahead of the new academic year.

As part of measures to address overcrowding and infrastructure challenges, the Mpumalanga Department of Education has procured 130 mobile classrooms. These will be deployed to schools experiencing high learner numbers, particularly in areas under pressure due to migration to urban centres.

MEC Masina also announced that furniture has been secured for 342 schools across the province. In addition, the department has

committed to repairing damages caused by recent floods before schools reopen on 14 January. Where extensive damage has occurred, assessments will be conducted, but alternative arrangements will be made to ensure that teaching and learning continue uninterrupted.

***"Our wish for 2026 is that it should be the year of growth, academic progress, safety and success for every learner and household in the province," said Masina.***

She further called on parents and communities to play an active role in supporting education and creating safe, supportive environments for learners.

The launch event also saw private sector support, with Old Mutual donating 50 pairs of school shoes to learners at Mathupa Primary School, adding a boost to the back-to-school drive in the Bushbuckridge area.

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SPIRITUAL REBIRTH

God Now Speaks Through His Son, Declares Letter to Hebrews

Jerusalem – A message attributed to early Christian teachers has revealed a profound proclamation: that God, who once spoke through prophets, has now spoken definitively through His Son.

The letter, addressed to believers, opens by stating that “In the past, God spoke to our ancestors through the prophets at many times and in various ways.” But now, it says, “in these last days, He has spoken to us by His Son,” whom He appointed heir of all things and through whom He made the universe.

This Son is described as “the radiance of God’s glory and the exact representation of His being,” upholding all things by His powerful word.

After providing purification for sins, He sat down at the right hand of the Majesty in heaven.

The letter emphasises that the Son is superior to angels, inheriting a name more excellent than theirs. No angel, it says, was ever called “Son” by God. Quoting Scripture, it adds: “You are my Son; today I have become your Father.”

Furthermore, when God brings His firstborn into the world, He commands: “Let all God’s angels worship Him.”

This bold theological declaration positions Jesus as central in divine revelation and cosmic authority.

Umalusi Assures Credible 2025 Results



Umalusi has assured South Africans that the 2025 end-of-year national examinations were conducted with integrity and credibility, following extensive quality assurance processes across the country.

Speaking at a media briefing in Pretoria on 9 January 2026, Umalusi Chief Executive Officer Dr Mafu Rakometsi confirmed that the education system was ready and capable of administering the 2025 examinations. The announcement followed an earlier readiness audit conducted in October 2025, which found that all assessment bodies were adequately prepared.

Umalusi quality assured four major qualifications in 2025: the General Education and Training Certificate for Adult Basic Education and Training, the NATED Engineering Studies N3, the National Certificate (Vocational) Level 4, and the National Senior Certificate (NSC). These qualifications were assessed by the Department of Basic Education, the Department of Higher Education and Training, the Independent Examinations Board and the South African Comprehensive Assessment Institute.

Dr Rakometsi also outlined important policy changes affecting post-school education. He confirmed that 2025 marked the final year in which Umalusi would issue new N3 certificates, following the phased-out NATED programmes.

However, he reassured the public that all previously issued N3 certificates remain valid. In addition, certificates will no longer be issued by Umalusi for NC(V)

Levels 2 and 3, with statements of results now issued by the Department of Higher Education and Training, while NC(V) Level 4 remains externally quality assured.

Umalusi’s quality assurance processes included moderation of question papers, monitoring of examination centres, verification of marking, and the standardisation of results to ensure fairness and comparability across years.

The standardisation process was overseen by the Assessment Standards Committee, supported by national and international observers from Southern Africa and beyond.

Addressing examination irregularities, Umalusi raised concerns about recurring cases of copying and unlawful practices



such as gatekeeping. The organisation welcomed recent court rulings affirming strict action against cheating, emphasising that hard work and honest study remain the foundation of credible qualifications.

Regarding the recent NSC examination paper leak, Umalusi confirmed that investigations found the breach to be localised, affecting about 40 candidates in Pretoria. The council assured the public that the incident does not compromise the overall credibility of the 2025 NSC results.

Umalusi concluded by congratulating the Class of 2025, parents, teachers and communities, while urging students to verify the accreditation status of institutions before enrolling for further studies.

CRIME  
Man Arrested After Domestic Violence Killing



A 45-year-old man has been arrested for murder following a domestic violence incident in which a 37-year-old woman was killed at Mashonamini Trust in Calcutta.

The incident took place on Thursday morning, 8 January 2026. According to police, officers received a complaint at about 08:00 reporting that a woman had allegedly been assaulted with a wooden stick by her husband.

Police responded promptly and were directed to a room at the residence, where the victim was found lying on the floor with no signs of life. Emergency Medical Services were called to the scene and confirmed that the woman had died.

At around 08:45, the suspect reportedly handed himself over to the police. He was immediately arrested and charged with murder.

The suspect is expected to appear before the Mkhuhlu Magistrate’s Court on Friday, 9 January 2026.

Police have reiterated that gender-based violence will not be tolerated and urged members of the public to seek help when experiencing conflict or abuse in their relationships.



# Persistent Rains Endanger Provincial Roads

Persistent heavy rainfall across parts of Mpumalanga continues to pose a serious threat to road safety, prompting the provincial Department of Public Works, Roads and Transport to urge motorists to exercise extreme caution when travelling.

According to the Department, continuous rainfall has significantly affected road conditions in several areas, resulting in slippery surfaces, flooded low-lying areas, collapsed culvert bridges and damage to sections of the provincial road network. These conditions increase the risk of accidents, particularly if motorists fail to adapt their driving behaviour.

MEC for Public Works, Roads and Transport, Mr Thomo, appealed to road users to prioritise safety at all times.

“The persistent rainfall we are experiencing in parts of the province requires all road users to be extra vigilant. We are appealing to motorists to reduce speed, maintain a safe following distance and strictly obey the rules of the road. Reckless driving under these conditions puts lives at risk, and we cannot afford to lose more lives on our roads,” he said.

The Department also cautioned that some road construction projects may experience temporary disruptions, as certain contractors are currently on festive season recess. Motorists have been urged to remain patient, adhere to road signage and respect temporary traffic control measures in areas under construction or repair.

Several roads have been closed due to unsafe conditions. These include the R533 between Graskop and Bushbuckridge, the D481 between Ekulindeni and Mooiplaas,

and the D1604 in Mbombela. The closures will remain in place until further notice.

The Department confirmed that it remains on high alert and is closely monitoring road conditions across the province in collaboration with relevant stakeholders to ensure the safety of all road users.

Motorists are encouraged to stay informed, plan their journeys carefully and avoid travelling through affected areas where possible.



# Three Motorists Arrested for Excessive Speeding



Traffic law-enforcement officers in Mpumalanga have arrested three motorists for excessive speeding on the N3 toll road between Villiers and Heidelberg during routine operations earlier this month.

According to the Mpumalanga Department of Community Safety, Security and Liaison, the arrests took place between 2 and 3 January 2026, with all three drivers exceeding the 120 km/h speed limit by a significant margin.

On 2 January, a 27-year-old man driving a Volkswagen Golf 7 was recorded travelling at approximately 169 km/h. A case of excessive speeding was opened at Grootvlei Police Station. On the same day, a 34-year-old man was detained after being

clocked at 164 km/h while driving a Toyota Corolla. He was also held at Grootvlei Police Station.

The third arrest occurred on 3 January, when a 36-year-old motorist was stopped while driving a Mercedes-Benz SUV at a speed of 174 km/h.

All three motorists were released on bail of R2 000 each and are expected to appear in court in due course.

The department has once again urged motorists to obey traffic laws and adhere to speed limits, warning that excessive speeding remains a major contributor to serious road accidents and fatalities, particularly during peak travel periods.



# Torrential Rains Impact Municipalities Across Region

Bushbuckridge Local Municipality continues to closely monitor the impact of ongoing torrential rains affecting various parts of Mpumalanga, while disaster management teams remain on high alert to ensure the safety of communities.

In neighbouring Thaba Chweu Local Municipality, no serious damage has been reported to date. However, the road between Graskop and Bushbuckridge has been closed as a safety precaution due to hazardous conditions caused by persistent rainfall.

Within Bushbuckridge Local Municipality, damage has been recorded at Thabokgolo Primary School, where strong winds blew away the roof of the school’s office block. In addition, 11 households were affected by the severe weather. The affected families have since received assistance, while damage assessments are still ongoing to determine the full extent of the impact.

Nkomazi Local Municipality has, so far, not reported any serious damage. Nevertheless,



residents living near the Driekoppies Dam have been placed on alert after the dam reached 104 per cent capacity. Authorities have indicated that the opening of the sluice gates may be required later this evening, depending on water levels.

The City of Mbombela has also been affected by the heavy rains. In Ward 43, at the Louisville-Kamashayana informal settlement, 64 households have been provided with relief material. Damage assessments are continuing, with a detailed report expected on Monday.

In Ward 29, Pienaar, approximately 150 houses have been affected, and disaster management teams are on the ground delivering relief and conducting assessments. Meanwhile, in Ward 18 at Entokozweni, about 18 houses have already been assessed, with further evaluations underway.

Residents are urged to remain vigilant and adhere to safety warnings as heavy rainfall continues across the region.

# Truck Driver Shot Dead in Bushbuckridge



Sphephelo Nxumalo (41), who was the driver of the vehicle.

Police said the motive for the murder is still unknown, and no arrests have been made at this stage. The suspects remain at large, and investigations are continuing. It has also been confirmed that the truck was fitted with cameras, and footage from these devices is being analysed as part of the investigation.

Police in Bushbuckridge have launched a manhunt following the fatal shooting of a truck driver along the R40 road at Dwarsloep earlier this week.

The incident occurred on Tuesday night, 6 January 2026, at around 23:40, when police responded to a complaint about a truck that was suspiciously and incorrectly parked along the route. Upon arrival at the scene, officers discovered a man lying on the ground outside the truck with a gunshot wound to the head.

Emergency medical services were called to the scene and declared the man dead on arrival.

The truck owner was later contacted and identified the deceased as Mr Scelo

The South African Police Service has appealed to members of the public to assist with information that may lead to the arrest of those responsible. Anyone with relevant information is urged to contact the investigating officer, Detective Lieutenant Colonel Cindy Mkhabela, on 082 469 1298, call Crime Stop on 08600 10111, or submit a tip via the MySAPS App. All information will be treated with strict confidentiality, and anonymity is guaranteed.

Police have also asked community members to come forward if they recognise a man shown in a photograph linked to the investigation, as this may assist in tracing the suspects.

The incident has raised concerns about safety along major transport routes in the area, as investigations continue.



# Mpumalanga Cracks Down on Unroadworthy Vehicles

Mpumalanga – The Department of Community Safety, Security and Liaison has identified 103 vehicles as unroadworthy and impounded a further 121 for serious traffic offences during recent operations across the province.

The offences included driving without a valid licence, operating vehicles without necessary permits, using potentially stolen or illegally imported vehicles, submitting fraudulent documentation, and failing to display proper registration discs.

Traffic law enforcement officers stopped and inspected more than 30,000 vehicles, with approximately 8,463 weighed to check compliance with load regulations. Over 4,600 traffic summonses were issued to drivers for various violations.

“These actions form part of ongoing efforts to reduce lawlessness and enhance road safety during the festive season,” the department said. They added that operations would continue throughout the holiday period. “Our officers remain committed to clamping down on unroadworthy vehicles and those carrying excessive loads as school closures approach,” the statement said.

MEC Jackie Macie urged all drivers, vehicle owners, and public transport operators to ensure their vehicles are properly maintained before setting off on journeys. “It is the responsibility of every owner to ensure their vehicles are roadworthy at all times. Neglecting defects endangers not only the driver but also other road users. Law enforcers will continue to hold owners accountable,”.





# Compliance Urged for Learner Transport Safety

Mpumalanga MEC for Public Works, Roads and Transport, Mr Thulasizwe Thomo, has called on all scholar transport operators in the province to ensure their vehicles are fully roadworthy and legally compliant ahead of the reopening of schools next week.

With thousands of learners expected to return to classrooms following the festive recess, MEC Thomo stressed that learner safety must remain the top priority for everyone involved in scholar transport services.

He urged operators to take full responsibility by ensuring vehicles are mechanically sound, properly licensed and driven by qualified, sober and responsible drivers.

***“Learner safety cannot be compromised. Operators must ensure that every vehicle transporting children meets all legal and safety requirements,” said Thomo.***

The MEC highlighted that vehicles used for

scholar transport must undergo thorough inspections, including checks on brakes, tyres and steering systems, in accordance with the National Road Traffic Act and related regulations.

He further warned that the Transport Inspectorate will intensify compliance monitoring across Mpumalanga, with a specific focus on scholar transport vehicles.

Operators found to be in violation of the law will face firm action, including fines, the impoundment of vehicles and possible

suspension of operating permits.

“We will not hesitate to act against operators who put the lives of our children at risk. Learners deserve to be transported in safe and reliable vehicles every day,” he added.

The department also appealed to parents, school management teams and community members to report unsafe scholar transport vehicles to the relevant authorities to help safeguard learners as the new school term begins.

## SAHPRA warns against illegal kids’ supplements

The South African Health Products Regulatory Authority (SAHPRA) has issued a warning against the sale of children’s supplements containing zinc picolinate and selenium, saying these ingredients are not permitted in health supplements for anyone under 18 because of safety concerns.

SAHPRA says the products are already on the market and are being promoted as “immune boosters”, with claims that they can help treat colds, flu, diarrhoea and skin-related conditions. The regulator has cautioned parents and caregivers to be vigilant when buying over-the-counter

supplements for children, especially those marketed as quick remedies for common illnesses.

Speaking on SAHPRA’s behalf, Tammy Gopal said zinc picolinate may cause side effects that could put children at risk.

“Zinc picolinate can cause side effects, including indigestion, diarrhoea, headache, nausea, and vomiting,” Gopal warned.

She said the sale of supplements containing these ingredients for children is illegal and that products intended for children must be

removed from circulation.

“The products currently on the market are sold as immune boosters and therefore, the sale of such products with these ingredients is illegal. The sale of medicines containing zinc picolinate or selenium intended for children must be withdrawn from the market,” said Gopal.

SAHPRA has urged members of the public who may have purchased these products for children to stop using them and return them to the point of supply, including their pharmacist, supplying warehouse or

distributor.

Parents are also encouraged to check labels carefully and to ask pharmacists for guidance before giving any supplement to a child. If a child becomes unwell after taking a supplement, caregivers should seek medical advice promptly and report the product through the appropriate health channels.

SAHPRA’s warning forms part of its ongoing work to protect consumers from unsafe or illegally marketed health products, particularly those aimed at vulnerable groups such as children.







# Police Clarify Komati River Rescue Claims

Police in Mpumalanga have moved to correct misinformation circulating on social media about an adult man frequently seen fishing at the Komati River in Komatipoort, amid claims that authorities failed to assist him.

In a media statement issued on 8 January 2026, the South African Police Service (SAPS) said it became aware of a widely shared video suggesting officers ignored a man who appeared to be in need of rescue. SAPS rejected these allegations, stressing that multiple attempts were made to assist the individual, who repeatedly refused help.

According to police, the man has developed a routine of fishing on rocks in the Komati River, an area regarded as dangerous due to wildlife risks. He was even observed continuing to fish during a televised SAPS interview linked to a separate search operation for two missing SANDF members whose vehicle had been swept away by the river.

On Wednesday, 7 January, an Emergency Medical Services (EMS) helicopter was dispatched to the area to remove the man to safety. However, police said he deliberately evaded rescue efforts and showed no

willingness to leave the river. The following day, after continued efforts, rescue teams managed to extract him safely, although he reportedly resisted leaving the area he considered his fishing spot.

Acting Provincial Commissioner of the SAPS in Mpumalanga, Major General (Dr) Zeph Mkhwanazi, emphasised that public safety remains a top priority for law enforcement agencies. He urged community members to act responsibly on social media

and avoid spreading unverified information that could cause unnecessary panic or undermine rescue operations.



“The SAPS remains devoted to protecting lives, including those of individuals who may not fully appreciate the risks they are taking,” Mkhwanazi said.

Police have again appealed to the public to cooperate with authorities and to share information responsibly.

# Two Arrested in Child Grooming Case

A 25-year-old woman and her alleged 33-year-old male associate have been arrested in Phola in connection with child grooming and statutory rape involving a 15-year-old girl.

The arrests followed a report made to police at about 10.10pm on Monday, 5 January 2026, by the victim's mother. She alleged that a woman at Oyco in Phola had encouraged and persuaded her teenage daughter to engage in sexual activities with several adult men in exchange for money.

According to police, preliminary investigations revealed that the victim frequently spent time at Oyco with friends, where the woman allegedly influenced her and other girls to have sexual encounters with men, who would then pay money that

was shared between the woman and the girls.

It is further alleged that on the morning of 5 January 2026, the woman compelled the teenager to have sexual intercourse with a 33-year-old man known to her and gave the child R100 in cash. Later the same day, at around 12.30pm, the woman allegedly coerced the victim into another sexual encounter with her purported male friend, who reportedly promised payment at a later stage.

The matter was referred to the Family Violence, Child Protection and Sexual Offences (FCS) Unit. Police traced the suspects to Oyco in the Four Room Section of Phola, where both were arrested on the same day.





# Alarming Rise in Teenage Pregnancies Sparks Call for Action

The Mpumalanga Department of Health has raised serious concern over the province’s growing teenage pregnancy crisis, after more than 9 000 cases were recorded last year. MEC for Health, Sasekani Manzini, described the figures as “alarming” and called for urgent legal and social interventions to protect underage girls.

Speaking at Shongwe Hospital while welcoming New Year babies on 1 January 2026, Manzini highlighted that teenagers continue to dominate the statistics of festive-season births. “We’re here today to welcome our New Year babies, which at present stand at more than 50 born across the province on this day alone,” she said.

“The first baby of the year was born in Emalahleni, where we were with the Premier on Christmas Day. Here at Shongwe Hospital, five babies had been delivered by midday.”



Manzini expressed particular concern over the number of mothers under the age of 16, noting that some cases could involve sexual abuse. “This is a serious social crisis that demands investigation,” she said. “Our department will collect data from affected teenagers to determine whether these pregnancies were forced or otherwise. Where perpetrators are identified, cases will be escalated to the Department of Social Development and legal authorities to ensure accountability.”

The MEC stressed that the recurring inclusion of girls under 14 among festive-season mothers is unacceptable. “Effective measures must be implemented to curb this scourge,” she added. “Perpetrators revealed by our investigations will face the full might of the law.”

During the festive season, a total of 171 babies were born on Christmas Day 2025, with 141 delivered on New Year’s Day across Mpumalanga health facilities. Twin

births included four sets, while New Year’s Day saw 78 girls and 63 boys delivered.

District statistics show Ehlanzeni recorded the highest number of teenage deliveries under 19, with 12 cases, followed by Nkangala (7) and Gert Sibande (6). Hospitals in Mammethlake, Witbank, and Standerton reported births involving girls aged 15 and 16.

“This is a social crisis that requires families, communities, and government to work together,” Manzini said, urging parents and communities to strengthen sexual and reproductive health education. “All cases involving minors will be reported to social workers to ensure proper investigation and support interventions.”



# Search Operation in Komatipoort Called Off



The South African Police Service (SAPS) in Mpumalanga has officially concluded the extensive search operation in Komatipoort following the tragic incident involving two South African National Defence Force (SANDF) members.

In a media statement issued on 1 January 2026, Acting Provincial Commissioner of the SAPS in Mpumalanga, Major General (Dr) Zeph Mkhwanazi, confirmed that the operation ended on 31 December 2025. This followed the discovery of remains believed to belong to the second missing SANDF member. DNA testing is still pending to confirm the identity.

Police have commended the dedication and resilience of the Search and Rescue teams, including the SAPS Diving Unit in Mpumalanga, who worked under extremely difficult and dangerous conditions. The operation was hampered by persistent heavy rainfall, swollen river levels and the presence of crocodiles and hippos in the Komati River, all of which posed serious risks to rescue personnel.

Despite these challenges, authorities say the tireless efforts of the teams have gone a long way towards providing closure to the families, friends and colleagues of the SANDF members involved. The operation relied heavily on cooperation between various agencies, with SAPS expressing

appreciation for the support received from SANParks, SANDF, Emergency Medical Services (EMS) and other role players.

Special recognition was also given to a member of the public who first reported the incident on 26 December 2025, triggering the search operation. A local resident was further acknowledged for voluntarily offering the use of his crane to assist in the recovery of the SANDF vehicle that was swept away by strong river currents.

SAPS has urged community members to exercise extreme caution during the rainy season, warning against swimming, fishing or attempting to cross flooded rivers and low-lying bridges. Residents were reminded that, apart from strong currents, rivers in the area are also home to dangerous wildlife such as crocodiles and hippos.

Major General Mkhwanazi emphasised the importance of collaboration shown throughout the operation, describing it as a reflection of unity and solidarity during times of tragedy. While the search has been concluded, he said SAPS and the Diving Unit will remain on standby should any new information emerge.

The SAPS has extended its deepest condolences to the affected families and reaffirmed its commitment to public safety.



# One-Stop Border Planned Between SA, Zimbabwe

The Border Management Authority (BMA) has announced plans to construct a one-stop border post between South Africa and Zimbabwe, a move expected to ease congestion and improve the flow of travellers and goods.

BMA Commissioner Dr Mike Masiapato said the new border facility would allow travellers and cargo trucks to be processed at a single point, instead of undergoing separate clearance procedures on each side of the border. This system is intended to streamline operations and significantly reduce delays at the port of entry.

In addition to the one-stop border post, the BMA is planning to build a new bridge on the western side of the Limpopo River. The bridge will be dedicated to cargo trucks, separating freight traffic from regular travellers and further easing congestion. Dr Masiapato said the project forms part of government’s broader strategy to modernise border infrastructure and improve regional trade. He confirmed that negotiations with

successful bidders under a public-private partnership arrangement are already under way.

**“The implementation of the one-stop border post is one of the key strategic interventions and decisions of the government of South Africa,” said Masiapato.**

“Negotiations are under way with successful bidders as far as the public-private partnership is concerned. On that basis, we can indicate that during the current year, 2026, we are going to start seeing this work gaining traction, to the extent that construction will begin sometime in the last quarter of the year.”

Once completed, the development is expected to enhance efficiency at the border, reduce long queues, and support economic activity between South Africa and Zimbabwe by improving the movement of people and goods across the border.



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## Bangwato Tournament Honours Trompies Matsane



The Bangwato Foundation successfully concluded its soccer and netball tournament, bringing together local teams in a celebration of sport, unity and remembrance.

The tournament was held in honour of the late Welcome "Trompies" Matsane, who initiated the Bangwato Foundation before his passing. Foundation president, Mr Mandla Matsane, blessed the occasion and paid tribute to Trompies' vision of uplifting the community through sport.

A total of 16 soccer teams competed in the tournament. Sindy Pirates Football Club emerged as champions, walking away with the top prize of R20 000. Eleven Experience secured second place and received R10 000, while Cork Vultures finished third and earned R6 000. Alexandria Cosmos claimed fourth place with a prize of R3 000.



All four semi-finalists also received soccer kits and balls.

The tournament also featured ladies' netball, with strong competition and enthusiastic support. Mathibela Netball Team were crowned champions and won R3 000. Mawunye Netball Team finished second and received R2 000, followed by Zama Zama in third place with R1 000. Khulong took fourth place and received R500. The top four netball teams were also awarded kits and balls.

The event highlighted the Bangwato Foundation's ongoing commitment to developing sport at grassroots level while honouring the legacy of Welcome "Trompies" Matsane, whose passion for community development continues to inspire many.

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